CREATOR RESEARCH · 04 / 04

Indian Creator Earnings Matrix

How creators earn on Instagram, by creator / audience gender pairing

Fifty-plus Indian creators across four creator × audience pairings, mapped against five income methods, with the reasoning behind each pattern.

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01 What this matrix shows

How do Indian creators actually earn on Instagram, and does it change with who the creator is and who the audience is? Creators are grouped by creator gender × audience gender, and each is ticked against five income methods.

READ THIS FIRST
Individual creators don't publish a per-method revenue breakdown, so the ticks and the Primary / Least notes reflect the documented earning pattern for that content niche (from industry reports), not a confirmed figure for each named person.

Method	What it is
Sponsored posts & brand partnerships	Flat fee from a brand to feature its product in a post, Reel or Story; rate depends on followers and engagement.
Affiliate marketing	Commission on every sale made through the creator's link or code.
UGC creation	Brands pay the creator to make content for the brand's own channels; no large following needed.
Sell digital products	E-books, presets, templates, courses, tutorials; high margin, no inventory.
Instagram Subscriptions	Paid exclusive content through Instagram's built-in feature (eligibility varies by region).

02 The four pairings at a glance

Pairing	Why sponsored posts lead	Why Instagram Subscriptions lag
Female Creator → Female Audience	Fashion/beauty/lifestyle brands pay the highest flat rates here, and this audience has the highest willingness to buy what's shown (Instagram users' avg purchase >$31, highest of any platform).	India's Subscriptions feature has patchy eligibility outside the US and this audience already gets free tutorials/hauls, so paying for exclusive content sees little uptake.
Female Creator → Male Audience	Gaming-hardware and telecom brands (Intel, Nvidia, Lenovo, Acer, Jio) pay premium sponsorship rates for credible female gaming creators specifically because they stand out in a male-dominated niche.	Live-streaming audiences on this niche route their spending through platform-native tools (Loco/Rooter gifting, YouTube Super Chat) rather than Instagram Subscriptions, so this line stays close to unused.
Male Creator → Male Audience	Tech, gaming and finance brand campaigns in this niche run largest (hobo.video cites collaborations reaching Rs 1-3 crore per partnership), and it's the category brands trust most for purchase-driving reach.	Same pattern as the other three groups - Subscriptions barely register because YouTube memberships/Discord already own the 'paid loyal community' role for this audience.
Male Creator → Female Audience	Fashion, cosmetics-for-men and F&B brands buy into dance reels for their huge organic reach and shareability, the same dynamic that gives dance the highest engagement rates of any content category.	This audience is younger and reel-native rather than loyalty-program native, so Subscriptions sees almost no adoption versus the other four channels.

PATTERN ACROSS ALL FOUR GROUPS
Instagram Subscriptions is the weakest method everywhere. Sponsored posts is the strongest or tied-strongest in every group. What separates the groups is the second method stacked on top of sponsorship: affiliate for female→female (shoppable fashion) and male→male (finance referrals), digital products for the expertise niches (finance, choreography), and little beyond sponsorship for the two reach-over-conversion groups (female→male gaming, male→female dance).

03 Full matrix by pairing

Top = primary income method for the group. ✓ = used – = not typical for the niche.

Female Creator → Female Audience

Creator	Content niche	Sponsored posts	Affiliate	UGC	Digital products	IG Subscriptions
Kritika Khurana (That Boho Girl)	Fashion, beauty, lifestyle	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–
Dolly Singh	Comedy, fashion, body positivity	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–
Kusha Kapila	Comedy, lifestyle, satire	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–
Komal Pandey	Fashion styling, outfit reels	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–
Sejal Kumar	Lifestyle, fashion vlogs	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–
Aashna Shroff (The Snob Journal)	Beauty, fashion	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–
Shruti Arjun Anand	Makeup tutorials, skincare	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–
Nancy Tyagi	Fashion, DIY couture	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–
Larissa D'Sa	Beauty, fashion	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–
Malvika Sitlani	Fashion, styling	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–
Isha Borah	Lifestyle, fashion	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–
Sowbaraniya Ramesh	Lifestyle, beauty, travel, food	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–
Shreemayi Reddy	Beauty, fashion, lifestyle	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–
Roshni Walia	Beauty, makeup looks	✓ Top	✓	✓	✓	–

Female Creator → Male Audience

Creator	Content niche	Sponsored posts	Affiliate	UGC	Digital products	IG Subscriptions
Payal Gaming (Payal Dhare)	Gaming (BGMI, GTA RP, Valorant)	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Kaash Plays (Kaashvi Hiranandani)	Gaming (BGMI, Valorant)	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Krutika Plays (Krutika Ojha)	Gaming (BGMI, Free Fire)	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Mizo (Mahek Syed)	Gaming (BGMI)	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Sharkshe S (Shakshi Shetty)	Gaming (BGMI, Valorant)	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Mili Kya Mili	Gaming, esports content	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Xyaa	Gaming	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Malaika Arora	Yoga, fitness	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Yasmin Karachiwala	Celebrity fitness training	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Natasha Noel	Yoga, wellness	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Nora Fatehi	Dance, bold performance content	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Urvashi Rautela	Glam, fashion, film promotion	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–

Male Creator → Male Audience

Creator	Content niche	Sponsored posts	Affiliate	UGC	Digital products	IG Subscriptions
CarryMinati (Ajey Nagar)	Gaming, comedy, roasts	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Total Gaming (Ajju Bhai)	Gaming (Free Fire, GTA 5)	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Techno Gamerz (Ujjwal Chaurasia)	Gaming (mobile, GTA, Minecraft)	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Dynamo Gaming (Aditya Sawant)	Gaming (BGMI)	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Mortal (Naman Mathur)	Gaming (BGMI, esports)	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Triggered Insaan (Nischay Malhan)	Gaming, comedy	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Elvish Yadav	Gaming, entertainment	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Technical Guruji (Gaurav Chaudhary)	Tech reviews, gadgets	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Trakin Tech (Abhishek Chaturvedi)	Tech reviews, smartphones	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Ranveer Allahbadia (BeerBiceps)	Podcast, self-improvement, finance	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Pranjal Kamra	Personal finance, investing	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Akshat Shrivastava	Finance, stock markets	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Ankur Warikoo	Finance, career, self-help	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Harsh Beniwal	Comedy, sketches	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–

Male Creator → Female Audience

Creator	Content niche	Sponsored posts	Affiliate	UGC	Digital products	IG Subscriptions
Awez Darbar	Dance, choreography	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Aadil Khan	Dance, couple content	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Faisal Shaikh (Faisu)	Dance, lip-sync, Team 07	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Adnaan Shaikh	Dance, comedy, Team 07	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Riyaz Aly	Dance, lifestyle, Team 07	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Hasnain Khan	Dance, Team 07	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Siddharth Nigam	Dance, acting-adjacent content	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Abhishek Nigam	Dance	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Karan Maru	Choreography, dance tutorials	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Mukul Gain (Mukul Sona MS)	Dance, reality-show fame	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Pavan Raghu N	Choreography (Hip-Hop, Zumba)	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–
Ansh	Dance, interactive reels	✓ Top	✓	–	✓	–

04 Why each category earns the way it does

Pairing	Reasoning
FEMALE → FEMALE Top: Sponsored posts + Affiliate Least: Subscriptions	This pairing has the deepest trust loop in Indian social media: fashion/beauty is the single biggest product-sales category for creators (30% of all creator product-sales revenue), and the audience actively shops off Reels rather than just watching. That makes both a flat sponsored fee AND a commission-per-sale (affiliate) work at the same time on the same post, which is why this group stacks the two highest-value methods instead of leaning on just one. Digital products (style guides, mini-courses) work as a third leg because the audience already treats these creators as a taste authority. Subscriptions lag because India's rollout of the feature has been limited and inconsistent, and the audience isn't used to paying for content it can already get for free in Reels/Stories.
FEMALE → MALE Top: Sponsored posts (hardware/telecom) Least: Subscriptions	A female creator succeeding in a male-coded niche (gaming) is itself the differentiator brands pay for — hardware companies specifically want to reach male gaming audiences through a credible female voice because it signals category growth and gets earned-media attention the way an all-male roster doesn't. That's why sponsorship rates for this group can rival or beat male peers with similar follower counts. Affiliate works moderately (coupon codes for peripherals/phones) but converts less directly than fashion, since gaming-hardware purchases are considered, high-ticket decisions, not impulse buys. Notably, several of these creators' own audiences skew more mixed or even female than expected — audience-gender data for creators like Payal Gaming shows a real female following too, which complicates a clean 'female-creator-for-male-audience' read and is worth validating before basing a strategy purely on niche assumptions. Subscriptions lose out to the live-streaming ecosystem (Loco, Rooter, YouTube Super Chat), which is already built for real-time fan payments and gets first claim on this audience's spending.
MALE → MALE Top: Sponsored posts (tech/gaming/finance) Least: Subscriptions	This is the highest-ceiling pairing in the whole matrix. Tech, gaming and finance are the three niches Indian brands pay the most for because the audience makes real purchase decisions off the content (a phone, a broker, a GPU), not just aspirational viewing — campaign values here run into the crore range for top creators, well above fashion/lifestyle rates. Affiliate is unusually strong specifically for finance creators, since trading-app and brokerage referral programs pay some of the highest per-signup commissions of any Indian affiliate vertical — this is the same mechanic the Zupee funnel in this project runs on. Digital products (courses, ebooks) are a real third stream here in a way they aren't for other groups, because finance/tech audiences are used to paying for expertise. Subscriptions still lose out — for this audience, YouTube memberships and Discord communities already do that job and were built first.

Pairing	Reasoning
MALE → FEMALE Top: Sponsored posts (fashion/F&B) Least: Subscriptions	Dance content has the highest organic engagement rate of any Indian content category, which is precisely why brands buy into it for reach rather than for direct product credibility — a dance reel sells awareness, not a considered purchase, so sponsorship (a flat fee for visibility) outperforms affiliate (a fee per sale) here more than in any other group. Affiliate still functions at a lower level through fashion product-tagging in outfit-focused dance content. A meaningful minority (choreographers like Karan Maru and Pavan Raghu N) run tutorials/academies, which is where digital products shows up for this group specifically — pure performers without a teaching angle see far less of that stream. Subscriptions again lag because this audience is young, reel-native, and used to free content, the same underlying reason it trails across all four groups.

PATTERN THAT HOLDS ACROSS ALL FOUR GROUPS

Instagram Subscriptions is the weakest method everywhere — not because any single niche dislikes it, but because India's version of the feature has had inconsistent availability, and every one of the four audiences already has a cheaper or more familiar way to pay a creator directly (buying tagged products, tipping on a livestream platform, joining a YouTube membership). Sponsored posts is the strongest or tied-strongest method in all four groups, which matches the country-wide data point that Instagram accounts for roughly 75% of total Indian creator revenue. The real differentiator between groups isn't whether they use sponsorship — everyone does — it's which second method stacks on top of it: affiliate for female-female (shoppable fashion) and male-male (finance referrals), digital products for niche-expertise groups (finance, choreography), and comparatively little beyond sponsorship for the two reach-over-conversion groups (female-male gaming, male-female dance).

05 Reference: 14 ways to earn on Instagram

Method	How it works
1- Sponsored Posts & Brand Partnerships	Partner with brands to promote their products/services in your posts or Stories. Rates depend on your follower count and engagement rate.
2- Affiliate Marketing	Share affiliate links (via bio or Stories) and earn a commission every time a follower makes a purchase through your link. Amazon, ShareASale, and LTK are popular platforms.
3 Sell Your Own Products (E-commerce)	Use Instagram Shopping to tag products directly in posts and Reels, driving traffic to your online store (Shopify, Etsy, etc.).
4- Sell Digital Products	Promote and sell e-books, presets, templates, courses, or printables. Low overhead and high margins since there's no physical inventory.
5- Offer Services	Use Instagram as a portfolio to attract clients for freelance work (photography, coaching, design, consulting, fitness training, et)c.
6- Instagram Subscriptions	Offer exclusive content to paying subscribers directly on Instagram through the built-in Subscriptions feature (available to eligible creators).
7- Badges in Instagram Live	Followers can purchase badges (small icons) during your Live videos as a way to support you, and you receive the money directly.
8- Reels Bonuses / Creator Programs	Instagram periodically offers monetization bonuses for Reels performance. Availability varies by region and account eligibility.
9- Sell Shoutouts	If you have a large or niche audience, other accounts or businesses will pay you to give them a shoutout to grow their following.
10- Dropshipping	Promote a dropshipping store through Instagram content and ads. You sell products without holding inventory the supplier ships directly to customers.
11- Flip Instagram Accounts	Build niche accounts from scratch, grow them to a solid follower count, and sell them on marketplaces like Fameswap or PlayerUp.
12- Run Instagram Ads for Clients (Agency/Freelance)	If you understand Instagram's ad platform, businesses will pay you to manage their paid campaigns and grow their presence.
13- Paid Online Courses & Memberships	Use Instagram to funnel your audience into a paid community or course platform (Teachable, Kajabi, Patreon, etc.).
14- UGC (User-Generated Content) Creation	Brands pay creators to make content for the brand's own channels you don't even need a large following, just strong content skills.